

GENTIANAS

Although there are gentians (*Gentiana*) large enough to hold their own in the herbaceous border, most are low-growing, deciduous or evergreen perennials, best suited to rock gardens, where they can form spreading mats. Flowering between spring and fall, they are renowned for their vivid blue, trumpet-shaped flowers, which are produced in pale shades (see as those of *G. 'Strathmore'*) to intensely dark ones (such as *G. acaulis*), although there are also white and yellow-flowered forms. All require a cool position, sheltered from hot summer sun. Most need light, rich, moist but well-drained neutral soil; fall-flowering species and cultivars, such as *G. sino-ornata*, require acidic conditions to thrive. Protect from slugs and snails, particularly in spring.



G. 'Strathmore'



G. 'Soutra'



G. saxosa



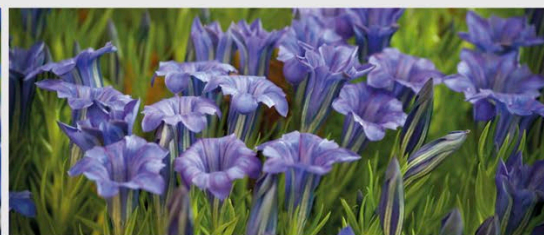
G. 'Ettrick'



G. 'Eugen's Allerbesten'



G. 'Blue Silk'



G. 'Shot Silk'



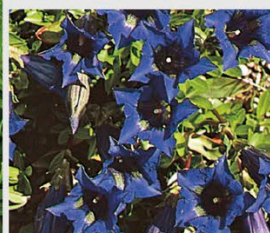
G. 'Inverleith'



G. sino-ornata



G. x macaulayi 'Wells's Variety'

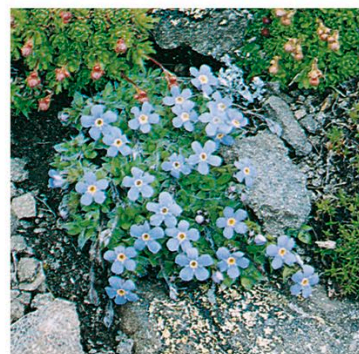


G. acaulis

SMALL

SUMMER

BLUE



Eritrichium nanum

Clump-forming perennial with tufts of hairy, gray-green leaves. Bears small, stemless, flat, pale blue flowers in late spring and early summer. Requires sharp drainage. Only suitable for an alpine house. **H** ¾in (2cm), **S** 1in (25cm).

☀️ ♂ Z5-7



Parochetus communis

(Shamrock pea)

Evergreen, prostrate perennial with cloverlike leaves and pealike, brilliant blue flowers that are borne almost continuously. Grows best in an alpine house. **H** 1-2in (2.5-5cm), **S** indefinite.

☀️ ♂ Z8-11



Polygala calcarea

Evergreen, prostrate, occasionally upright, perennial. Has small, narrowly ovate leaves and pale to dark blue flowers in late spring and early summer. Likes humus-rich soil. Suits a trough. May be difficult to establish. **H** 1in (25cm), **S** to 6in (15cm).

☀️ ♂ Z7-9